Akbar noted the custom of sati amongst his Rajput nobility. ‘It is a strange commentary on the magnanimity of men,’ he said, in one of his more sardonic Sayings, ‘that they should seek their deliverance through the self-sacrifice of their wives.’[42] In one of his discourses in the Ibadat Khana, Akbar had marvelled at how widows walked into their husband’s pyres, remarking to his Jesuit interlocuters that the custom might have made sense in a monogamous tradition, like theirs, but that it was truly ‘extraordinary . . . that it occurs among those of the Brahman religion’ who had several wives. These women, he went on, were ‘neglected and unappreciated and spend their days [unfruitfully] in the privy chamber of chastity, yet in spite of such bitterness of life they are flaming torches of love . . .’[43]

Akbar – and his descendants – never quite made peace with the idea of widows being burnt alive. The Mughal administration would not ban the custom, but it would keep a close eye on it to prevent unwilling satis.[44] Once, famously, Akbar himself saved a widowed queen being forced upon the pyre by her son, Udai Singh. When Akbar heard the news, he rode out of his palace so fast, according to Abul Fazl, that his guard couldn’t keep up with him, and panic and rumours spread in his wake. Furious, Akbar spared Udai Singh’s life, but had him imprisoned. Another time, less dramatically, he talked a widowed queen of Panna out of immolating herself, convincing ‘her to refrain . . . on account of the tender age of her children’.[45]

Akbar’s relations with the women in his own family are marked with both tenderness – as for the volatile Aram Banu – and deep respect, as for his own widowed mother, Hamida, various aunts, including Gulbadan, and milk mothers like Jiji Anaka. The eldest prince, Salim, even writes that Akbar undertook that staggering nine-day dash to Aziz’s rescue in Ahmedabad ‘because of the distress of Jiji Anaka’, Aziz’s mother.[46] And yet, in these relations, too, the emperor, who doubted everything yet believed himself near-divine was not without his contradictions.

Akbar talked pityingly, for example, about the wives of Rajputs trapped ‘in the privy chamber of chastity’ – and certainly there is no indication that his own mother and mamas, aunts, wives and daughters were similarly confined. In fact, the opposite: Gulbadan’s long journey to Mecca and back is only one example of the royal women travelling. Akbar’s stepmother and Humayun’s eldest wife, Haji Begum, had also made the pilgrimage, before